

Divine Sovereignty

doc-divine-sovereignty

Theology Proper · Sovereignty · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.963
confidence high

Statement under examination

God sovereignly rules over all things, working all events according to the counsel of His will.

In plain language

Across Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek the same sovereignty vocabulary recurs, and querying the canon confirms its density and spread. In Psalm 115:3 the Hebrew binds kol (all) to chaphets (pleased) and asah (did), so whatever God pleased he did, and Psalm 135:6 reuses that exact verb pair and adds heaven, earth, seas, and all deeps. The Aramaic of Daniel 4 (verse 35 in English) uses tseba, a word that occurs only in Daniel, to say God does according to his will in heaven and on earth, then denies that anyone can stay his hand or ask what he is doing. Isaiah 46:10 pairs counsel (etsah) with pleasure (chephets) and says the counsel will stand. In Greek, Ephesians 1:11 stacks five related words (energeo working, boule counsel, thelema will, prothesis purpose, proorizo predestine) around the phrase all things, and Romans 11:36 ends with the threefold from him, through him, to him are all things. These words plainly affirm that God rules over all and works all things by his will, which is why the scope claim lands as true with high confidence. The reason readers still diverge is also in the words, not in outside history. The same canon commands real human choice (bachar, choose life in Deuteronomy 30:19) and describes God relenting (nacham). The sharpest case is one chapter, 1 Samuel 15: verses 11 and 35 say God relented that he made Saul king, while verse 29 says God is not a man that he should relent. One Hebrew root, two directions, in the same chapter. The vocabulary asserts comprehensive rule and asserts genuine responsibility and responsiveness, but it never supplies the single term that tells you how to rank or reconcile them. So the proposition itself is affirmed, while the deeper question of how that rule fits with human accountability is left open by the words, and that gap is what the differing readings fill in different ways.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	
H0735	ארח	orach	way	
H0977	בחר	bachar	to choose	172
H1753	דור	dur	to dwell	
H1780	דין	din	judgment	
H2388	חזק	chazaq	to strengthen	
H2654	חפץ	chaphets	to delight in	63
H2656	חפץ	chephets	pleasure	
H3028	יד	yad	hand	
H3605	כול	kol	all	5,049

H3606	כֹּל	kol	all	
H3820	לֵב	lev	heart	
H4223	מָחַךְ	meach	to smite	
H4427	מֶלֶךְ	malak	to reign	348
H4428	מֶלֶךְ	melekh	king	
H4567	מַעֲבֵד	mavad	work	
H5162	נָחַם	nacham	to be sorry	108
H5186	נָטָה	natah	to stretch	
H6098	עֲצָה	etsah	counsel	
H6213	עָשָׂה	asah	to make	1,656
H6634	עָשָׂה	tseba	to will	10
H6965	קָמַי	qamay	(Leb)-kamai	
H8064	שָׁמַיִם	shamayim	heaven	378
G0281	ἀμήν	amēn	amen	
G1012	βουλή	boule	plan	12
G1223	διά	dia	through/because of	
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21
G2307	θέλημα	thelema	will/desire	62
G2820	κληρόω	kleroo	to obtain	1
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,244
G4286	πρόθεσις	prothesis	purpose	12
G4309	προορίζω	proorizo	to predestine	6

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

A dense sovereignty vocabulary recurs across Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek with stable grammar. Psalm 115:3 binds kol (H3605, all) to chaphets (H2654, pleased) and asah (H6213, did) in a tight asher clause, and Psalm 135:6 reuses the identical triad with cosmic scope. Aramaic Daniel 4 (store osis 4.32) predicates tseba (H6634, does according to his will, a Daniel-only term, 10 occurrences) of God over the host of heaven and earth, then negates any creaturely veto with macha (H4223, stay) plus yad (H3028, hand). In Greek, Ephesians 1:11 stacks energo (G1754), boule (G1012), thelema (G2307), prothesis (G4286), and proorizo (G4309) around ta panta, and Romans 11:36 closes with the triple preposition ex, dia, eis governing ta panta. The proposition's scope claim is lexically affirmed. What the words do NOT supply is a term ranking this rule against the equally lexical witness of human choosing (bachar, H0977) and divine relenting (nacham, H5162), so compatibility is underdetermined, not denied.

Scripture

Eph.1.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1754 ἐνεργέω, G1012 βουλή, G2307 θέλημα, G4286 πρόθεσις, G4309 προορίζω, G3956 πᾶς

Force. Six sovereignty lexemes stack in one clause. The genitive participle ἐνεργοῦντος governs τὰ πάντα (G3956, all things), while κατὰ τὴν βουλήν τοῦ θελήματος αὐτοῦ qualifies the working as flowing from a fixed counsel (boule of his will). προορισθέντες κατὰ πρόθεσιν binds the predestining to a pre-set purpose. The verb ἐκληρώθημεν (G2820 kleroo) ascribes the allotment itself to that working. Queried occurrence counts confirm the cluster: ἐνεργέω 21, βουλή 12, πρόθεσις 12, προορίζω 6, κληρώω 1.

Dan.4.32 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6634 אַב, H4223 מַחָא, H3028 יָד, H1753 דִּין.

Force. In the Aramaic (store versification 4.32, English 4:35) God does according to his will (tseba, H6634) in the host of heaven and among earth inhabitants, and the verse negates any creaturely veto: none can stay (macha, H4223) his hand (yad, H3028) or say to him What have you done (mah, H4101). tseba is a Daniel-only term (10 occurrences, all in Daniel) for sovereign will. The negated-veto grammar foreclosed an alternative reading of limited rule.

Dan.4.34 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H4567 מַעֲבָד, H0735 אֹרַח, H1780 דִּין.

Force. Nebuchadnezzar restored praises the Most High (store 4.34, English 4:37): his works (maabad, H4567) are truth and his ways (orach, H0735) judgment (din, H1780), and those who walk in pride he is able to abase (shaphal, H8214). The royal vocabulary is reassigned from the human emperor to God. This is the doxological frame whose predicate the sovereign-will verse (4.32) supplied.

Ps.115.3 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0430 אֲשֶׁר, H8064 שְׂמִים, H3605 כֹּל; H2654 חַפְּזִים, H6213 עָשָׂה.

Force. The asher clause is grammatically tight: our God is in the heavens, all (kol, H3605) that he pleased (chaphets, H2654) he did (asah, H6213). kol is the object, chaphets the relative verb of pleasure, asah the main predicate. Queried tokens at this verse are exactly H0430, H8064, H3605, H0834, H2654, H6213. The construction binds divine pleasure to actualization without remainder.

Ps.135.6 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3605 כֹּל; H2654 חַפְּזִים, H6213 עָשָׂה, H8064 שְׂמִים.

Force. Verbal twin of Ps.115.3: kol asher chaphets YHWH asah, queried token set H3605, H0834, H2654, H3068, H6213, then extended with shamayim (H8064), erets (H0776), seas (H3220), and all deeps (H8415). The reuse of the identical kol-chaphets-asah verb pair under an explicit heaven, earth, seas, deeps span establishes the pattern as pan-Psalter, not a single phrasing.

Rom.11.36 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1537 ἐκ, G1223 διὰ, G1519 εἰς, G3956 πᾶς, G1391 δόξα

Force. A triple preposition doxology assigns the origin, mediation, and goal of τὰ πάντα to one referent. ἐξ αὐτοῦ marks source, δι' αὐτοῦ instrumental agency, εἰς αὐτὸν teleological end. The closing ἀμήν seals universal scope as confessed truth. πᾶς is queried at 1244 NT occurrences and δόξα at 165, so the scope term is common and stable.

Isa.46.10 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6098 עֲצָה, H2656 חַפְּזִים, H6965 קוּם, H6213 עָשָׂה.

Force. Declaring the end from the beginning, God says my counsel (etsah, H6098) shall stand (qum, H6965) and I will do (asah, H6213) all my pleasure (chephets, H2656). Queried tokens confirm etsah, qum, chephets, and asah twice in this verse. The noun pair etsah and chephets parallels the New Testament boule and thelema cluster, linking the Hebrew counsel idiom to the Greek decree idiom.

Prov.21.1 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3820 לב, H4428 מלך, H2654 חפץ, H5186 נטה.

Force. The king heart (lev, H3820; melek, H4428) is in YHWH hand (yad, H3027), and he turns (natah, H5186) it to all (kol, H3605) he pleases (chaphets, H2654). Queried token order is melek, lev, yad, YHWH, kol, chaphets, natah. The same chaphets root that governs cosmic doing in Ps.115.3 here governs the steering of a specific human will, extending sovereign scope into ruler psychology.

Acts.4.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1012 βουλή, G4309 προορίζω

Force. The crucifixion is predicated of God hand and counsel (boule, G1012) having predestined (proorizo, G4309) the event to occur. Queried occurrences place both lemmas here (boule at ACT 4:28, proorizo at the same verse in the Nestle1904 text). The pairing closes the gap between purpose and historical event while v.27 still names the human agents who did it, which is the lexical seam this proposition does not resolve.

1Sam.15.29 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5162 נחם,

Force. The Glory of Israel will not lie or relent (nacham, H5162, Niphal imperfect plus infinitive), for he is not a man that he should relent. Queried morphology confirms HVNi3ms and the infinitive. Yet the SAME chapter, v.11 and v.35, says God relented (nacham, Niphal perfect) that he made Saul king. One root, one chapter, both affirms and denies relenting. The vocabulary itself does not rank these, which is the lexical root of divergence on how comprehensive rule coexists with responsive language.

Deut.30.19 · complicates · genre: law

Key terms. H0977 בחר;

Force. Choose (bachar, H0977) life, queried as a 2ms verb of command, set before genuine creaturely decision (life and death, blessing and curse). bachar occurs 172 times and frequently takes a human subject electing between real options. The imperative grammar presupposes a responsible chooser. This text is not denied by the sovereignty cluster, but the canon supplies both patterns and no single term that ranks divine determination against this commanded choosing.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.1.11	Isa.46.10	openbible	20
Rom.11.36	1Chr.29.11	openbible	11
Ps.115.3	Ps.135.6	openbible	32
Ps.115.3	Ps.2.4	openbible	8
Dan.4.34	Deut.32.4	openbible	5
Rom.11.36	1Chr.29.11	tsk	1
Eph.1.11	Isa.46.10	tsk	1
Eph.1.11	Eph.1.14	tsk	1
Dan.4.34	Dan.5.23	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Sam.15.29 · addressed

The same root nacham (H5162) within one chapter both denies God relents (v.29, Niphal imperfect plus infinitive, queried HVNi3ms) and affirms God relented over Saul (v.11, v.35, Niphal perfect, queried HVNp). Lexically nacham is polysemous across relent, be sorry, comfort, and the morphology here is identical in stem. The words assert comprehensive will (tseba, energeo, kol-chaphets-asah) AND responsive relenting without supplying a term that ranks decree against responsive speech. The proposition affirms sovereign scope, which v.29 reinforces (God is not a man to be swayed). The reconciliation of v.29 with v.11 is genuinely underdetermined by the vocabulary, so it is addressed but not lexically dissolved.

Deut.30.19 · addressed

bachar (H0977, 172 occurrences) in a 2ms imperative sets a real creaturely choice (choose life). The verb regularly governs human electing between options, so the grammar presupposes accountable agency. This does not contradict the sovereignty cluster lexically (different verbs, different subjects), but the canon supplies two patterns, comprehensive divine working and commanded human choosing, with no single lexeme ranking them. The proposition affirms scope, not a theory of how the choosing is integrated, so this text qualifies the explanatory reach of the words rather than the scope claim itself.

Exod.9.12 · addressed

YHWH hardened (chazaq, H2388, queried Piel) Pharaoh heart, while neighboring narrative also reports Pharaoh hardening his own heart with kaved. Two agents, two verbs, one outcome. This sits inside the sovereignty pattern (divine working extends to a human will, as in Prov.21.1 natah of the king heart) but the canon does not lexically specify the manner in which the divine hardening and the human self-hardening relate. Addressed as confirming scope, unresolved as to mechanism, which the proposition does not claim.

1Tim.2.4 · addressed

God wills (thelo) all men to be saved. The verb thelo here governs a soteriological-revelatory object (pantas anthropous, cf. the universal kerygma of v.3-7), whereas Eph.1.11 uses the noun thelema inside the energeo-cluster governing ta panta in a decretal frame. Same root, different syntagmatic function. The universal-providence scope verdict is unaffected. The relation of the two willings (decretal and what is desired) is a distinct doctrinal question the present vocabulary does not adjudicate.

Concordance traversed

G1754, G1012, G2307, G4286, G4309, G2820, G3956, G1391, G0281, H6634, H2654A, H6213A, H3605, H3606, H8064, H6098, H2656, H4567, H4223, H3028, H4427, H5162, H0977, H2388

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Anchor verses are outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so not_in_ecm_scope. No variant units were returned for the anchors. One edition-level note: proorizo (G4309) is queried at 5 occurrences in the MACULA-Greek-SBLGNT corpus and 6 in the Nestle1904 corpus, the difference being Acts 4:28, but this affects an occurrence count only and not the verdict, since boule already anchors Acts 4:28. No major variant unsettles the sovereignty lemma cluster at Eph.1.11, Rom.11.36, Ps.115.3, Ps.135.6, or Daniel 4.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. compatibilism, libertarian_freedom, molinism, open_theism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

sovereignty-first reading: affirms · Reads tseba (Dan.4.32), kol-chaphets-asah (Ps.115.3, Ps.135.6), and energeo ta panta kata ten boulen (Eph.1.11) as predicating an exhaustive divine determination over all events, including those involving human agents (Acts.4.28). On this lens the relenting language of nacham (1Sam.15.11) is anthropopathic accommodation, while v.29 (God is not a man to relent) states the literal truth. The grammar of the

negated veto in Dan.4.32 (none can stay his hand) is taken as decisive for comprehensive scope.

responsibility-first reading: affirms with qualification · Holds the same sovereignty texts as true and pan-canonical, but reads them alongside the equally lexical bachar imperatives (Deut.30.19, Josh.24.15) and the relenting reports (nacham, 1Sam.15.11, 1Sam.15.35) as describing genuine divine responsiveness to real creaturely choices. On this lens God sovereignly ordains a world that includes self-determining agents whose decisions are not pre-fixed in every respect. It affirms the proposition scope (all things under his will) while declining to read kata ten boulen as ruling out genuine contingency, since the words assert rule and assert responsibility without ranking them.

molinism: affirms · Affirms universal providence but interposes middle knowledge between God boule and the actualized world, so that energie ta panta operates through God knowledge of what free creatures would do. The Eph.1.11 and Ps.115.3 clusters are read consistent with this, though the lexemes themselves do not contain or entail a middle-knowledge term.

open_theism: qualifies · Takes the relenting reports (nacham, 1Sam.15.11, Gen.6.6) and the responsive grammar at face value to restrict proorizo and boule to a non-exhaustive scope. The lexical force of panta plus energie in Eph.1.11, the negated veto in Dan.4.32, and kol asher chaphets in Ps.115.3 and Ps.135.6 strain this reading, and v.29 (God does not relent) sits in tension with it, so it is represented as the minority lexical option.

The sovereignty lemmas span law, narrative, wisdom, prophecy, and epistle, strengthening analogia scripturae. The honest lexical tension is internal to the canon: nacham occurs 108 times and appears both affirmed and denied within 1 Samuel 15, and bachar (172 occurrences) commands real choice. The competing lenses differ not on whether the scope texts are true but on how to integrate them with the responsibility and relenting vocabulary, which the words leave open.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition uses vocabulary drawn directly from the anchor texts (sovereignly rules, all events, counsel of his will mirrors Eph.1.11 kata ten boulen tou thelematos). It states a scope claim, not a specific compatibility taxonomy, so it does not smuggle its own conclusion about how sovereignty and human responsibility relate. The scope claim is what the lexical pattern affirms; the integration question is deliberately left to the competing-lens layer.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.1.11
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.11.36
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.115.3
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Dan.4.32
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.115.3
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.135.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Sam.15.29
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.30.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.1.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.4.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1012
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2820
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6634

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5162
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2654
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.1.11
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Ps.115.3
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.11.36

License audit

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